CHAPTER 80 Role of Regional Parties

The presence of a large number of regional parties is an important feature of the Indian Political System. They have come to play a vital role in Indian politics at all levels, i.e. local, state and national. This is more so in the context of the new era of coalition politics.

FEATURES

Following are the features of a regional party:

1. It generally operates within a particular state or specific region. Its electoral base is limited to a single region.
2. It articulates regional interests and identifies itself with a particular cultural, religious, linguistic or ethnic group.
3. It is primarily concerned with exploiting the local resources of discontent or preserving a variety of primordial demands based on language, caste or community or region[1].
4. It focuses on local or regional issues and aims to capture political power at the state level.
5. It has a political desire for greater regional autonomy of states in the Indian Union[2].

CLASSIFICATION

The various regional parties in India can be classified into the following four categories:

1. Those regional parties which are based on the regional culture or ethnicity. These include Shiromani Akali Dal, National Conference, DMK, Telugu Desam, Shiv Sena, Asom Gana Parishad and so on.
2. Those regional parties which have an all-India outlook but lack a national electoral base. The examples are Samajwadi Party, Nationalist Congress Party and so on.
3. Those regional parties which have been formed by a split in national parties. For example, Biju Janata Dal, Rashtriya Janata Dal, Trinamool Congress, YSR Congress and so on.
4. Those regional parties which have been formed by individual leaders on the basis of their charismatic personality. These are called as personalised parties and they are short-lived.

RISE

There are multiple reasons for the emergence of regional parties in India. These are as follows:

1. Cultural and ethnic pluralism of the Indian society.
2. Economic disparities and regional imbalances in the development.
3. Desire of certain sections or areas to maintain separate identity due to historical factors.
4. Self-interest of the deposed Maharajas and dispossessed Zamindars.